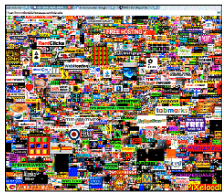




**148** Civilization IV



**154** Five Months To A Million



**168** "No eLay," says Electra

# Digital Leisure

Technology Beyond Work

## Lead Feature

# Are Viruses Alive?

**That's what I asked myself one day. Finding an answer, however, was a lot harder than I thought!**

### Agent 001

For billions of years, viruses have infected their way across the Earth. New studies suggest that the first life forms on our planet might not have been bacteria or amoeba-like cells, but viruses! Debates still rage over whether a virus can be considered alive, since it's just strands of DNA with some protein attached to it. Viruses are a lot smaller than the average cell, and come in all different shapes and sizes. My personal belief has always been that they're alive: they reproduce, respond to the environment, are capable of evolving, and use energy. They ~sound~ alive, don't they?

However, the question I asked myself had nothing to do with these little biological pests; I was asking myself if the average computer worm, Trojan or virus could be considered a living entity. Yes it sounds strange, especially since we've not even reached the stage where we can consider a computer, robot or software to be intelligent. We haven't developed a self-learning Arti-

cial Intelligence (AI), despite decades of research. We're getting closer though-evolving robots and adaptive software seem to be the answer for now. If we finally develop true AI, say, a decade down the line, what happens if people start developing intelligent viruses?

### Un-killable Viruses!

A scary thought, but one we should think about. Do we really want to create AI? I know for sure

I don't want to have to deal with a virus that can ~think~! I would need intelligent anti-virus and anti-spyware applications that run all the time to try and stop these thinking viruses! What does that do for my system performance? So 10 years down the line I might have a Terahertz CPU with a TB of RAM, but my anti-virus will still use a lot of my resources - perhaps more so when scanning and battling smart viruses! But remember that these viruses are

